

Business

1. Coupang, South Korea's biggest e-commerce company, recently received a record \$410 million fine from regulators over a massive customer-data leak. What happened to its share price immediately after the fine was announced?
 - a. It fell 8% as investors priced in reputational damage
 - b. It surged 14.1% as investors saw the penalty as drawing a line under the uncertainty
 - c. It barely moved as markets had already priced in a larger fine
2. Yakult, the Japanese probiotic drink maker, has just sparked an unlikely consumer controversy in Singapore. What did it do?
 - a. It raised the price of its original red-bottle drink by 40%
 - b. It shrunk the bottle size while keeping the price the same
 - c. It replaced its orange-flavoured drink with a peach version
3. Rising fuel prices linked to the Middle East conflict are reshaping how people get around in Kenya. Thousands of riders have recently been abandoning fuel-powered motorcycles — known locally as boda bodas — for a cheaper alternative. What is driving this shift across the industry?
 - a. A government subsidy programme offering free bus passes to registered riders
 - b. The rapid adoption of electric motorbikes, which cost far less to run per kilometre
 - c. A new Chinese-backed ride-hailing app undercutting fuel-bike operators on price
4. GRO, a Ukrainian-founded AI fintech startup, just made an unusual strategic move after securing backing from Qatar's newly launched GrowthX Capital fund. What did it do?
 - a. It listed on the Nasdaq stock exchange to access US retail investors
 - b. It acquired a rival Ukrainian startup to consolidate the local market
 - c. It relocated its headquarters from Ukraine to Doha, Qatar

Economics

5. US inflation (the rate at which prices rise across the economy) hit 4.2% annually in May — a three-year high — driven largely by higher fuel costs from the Iran conflict. Why does a war in Iran push up fuel prices in the US?
 - a. Iran is the US's largest oil supplier, so sanctions directly cut American supply
 - b. Iran's position near the Strait of Hormuz, through which about 20% of the world's oil flows, creates supply-disruption fears that push up global prices
 - c. Iran controls the pricing formula used by OPEC, so conflict there triggers automatic production cuts

6. The European Central Bank (ECB) recently raised its deposit facility rate (the interest rate it pays banks for holding money overnight) by 0.25% to 2.25%, its first rate increase in three years. Which of these is NOT a genuine risk of raising interest rates to fight inflation?
 - a. It raises borrowing costs for households and businesses, potentially slowing growth
 - b. It can strengthen the euro, making European exports more expensive abroad
 - c. It directly increases the price of imported oil, adding to the inflation it is trying to fight
7. Japan has recently announced plans to explore rare-earth mining in Greenland as early as this summer. Rare earths are a group of minerals essential for electric motors, wind turbines, and chips. Why is this geopolitically significant?
 - a. Greenland currently bans all foreign mining, so Japan would be breaking new legal ground
 - b. Japan is trying to reduce its heavy dependence on China, which dominates global rare-earth production and supply
 - c. The US has ordered Japan to secure alternative rare-earth sources as a condition of its trade deal
8. South Korea's exports of ICT (information and communication technology) products hit an all-time monthly record in May. How much did those shipments amount to, despite a broader global economic slowdown?
 - a. Around \$28 billion
 - b. Around \$38 billion
 - c. Around \$48 billion

General Knowledge

9. Chile is one of the most economically significant countries in the world for a single commodity that is now critical to electric vehicle batteries and grid storage. Which mineral is Chile the world's largest producer of?
 - a. Cobalt
 - b. Lithium
 - c. Nickel
10. This Scottish economist, writing in 1776, argued that the wealth of nations came not from stockpiling gold but from productive labour and free exchange — a radical idea at the time. Who was he?
 - a. David Hume
 - b. Adam Smith
 - c. John Stuart Mill

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1. Coupang, South Korea's biggest e-commerce company, recently received a record \$410 million fine from regulators over a massive customer-data leak. What happened to its share price immediately after the fine was announced?

b. Coupang's shares jumped 14.1% on the news. Counterintuitively, the fine — though a record for South Korea's privacy regulator — ended six months of regulatory uncertainty, and markets prefer a known bad outcome to an unknown one. It's a classic example of 'bad news is good news' when the bad news is smaller or cleaner than feared.

2. Yakult, the Japanese probiotic drink maker, has just sparked an unlikely consumer controversy in Singapore. What did it do?

c. Yakult swapped its orange-flavoured probiotic drink for a peach version in Singapore, and fans were not happy. The backlash is a reminder that flavour loyalty runs surprisingly deep — consumers who barely noticed gradual price rises reacted strongly to a taste change. Food brands call this the 'reformulation trap.'

3. Rising fuel prices linked to the Middle East conflict are reshaping how people get around in Kenya. Thousands of riders have recently been abandoning fuel-powered motorcycles — known locally as boda bodas — for a cheaper alternative. What is driving this shift across the industry?

b. Soaring fuel costs have made electric motorbikes dramatically cheaper to run, triggering record sales and a genuine structural shift in Kenya's urban transport. Boda bodas are the backbone of last-mile delivery and commuting across East Africa, so electrifying them matters far beyond individual riders — it's reshaping logistics, emissions, and energy demand across the region.

4. GRO, a Ukrainian-founded AI fintech startup, just made an unusual strategic move after securing backing from Qatar's newly launched GrowthX Capital fund. What did it do?

c. GRO is moving its base of operations to Doha after landing Qatari investment. For startups founded in conflict zones, securing a stable legal and financial home in a Gulf state is an increasingly common playbook — Qatar, the UAE, and Saudi Arabia have all been actively courting European and Eastern European tech companies with capital and a calmer operating environment.

Economics

5. US inflation (the rate at which prices rise across the economy) hit 4.2% annually in May — a three-year high — driven largely by higher fuel costs from the Iran conflict. Why does a war in Iran push up fuel prices in the US?

b. The Strait of Hormuz is one of the world's most critical energy chokepoints — roughly one-fifth of global oil supply passes through it. When conflict threatens that corridor, oil markets price in potential disruption even before a single tanker is delayed. Higher oil prices feed into fuel, then transport, then almost everything else — which is why geopolitics and grocery bills are connected.

6. The European Central Bank (ECB) recently raised its deposit facility rate (the interest rate it pays banks for holding money overnight) by 0.25% to 2.25%, its first rate increase in three years. Which of these is NOT a genuine risk of raising interest rates to fight inflation?

c. Higher interest rates do not directly raise oil prices — oil is priced in dollars on global commodity markets, and the ECB has no control over that. The other two are real risks: dearer mortgages and business loans can tip an economy into recession, and a stronger currency can hurt exporters. The ECB is betting those costs are worth bearing to bring inflation back down.

7. Japan has recently announced plans to explore rare-earth mining in Greenland as early as this summer. Rare earths are a group of minerals essential for electric motors, wind turbines, and chips. Why is this geopolitically significant?

b. China controls roughly 60% of global rare-earth mining and an even larger share of processing capacity, giving it significant leverage over countries building green-energy and defence supply chains. Japan — which has almost no domestic mineral resources — has been burned before when China restricted rare-earth exports during a territorial dispute in 2010. Greenland's vast, largely untapped geology makes it an attractive diversification target.

8. South Korea's exports of ICT (information and communication technology) products hit an all-time monthly record in May. How much did those shipments amount to, despite a broader global economic slowdown?

c. South Korea's ICT exports reached \$47.79 billion in May — close to \$48 billion — the highest single-month figure ever recorded. The surge was driven by insatiable demand for semiconductors and AI-related chips. South Korea's two giants, Samsung and SK Hynix, make the high-bandwidth memory chips that sit inside most AI servers, meaning the global AI boom shows up directly in Korean export data.

General Knowledge

9. Chile is one of the most economically significant countries in the world for a single commodity that is now critical to electric vehicle batteries and grid storage. Which mineral is Chile the world's largest producer of?

b. Chile holds the world's largest lithium reserves and is its biggest producer, accounting for roughly a quarter of global supply. Its Atacama Desert contains vast salt flats where lithium-rich brine is pumped to the surface and evaporated. As EV demand grows, Chile's lithium has become a major strategic asset — the government has moved to increase state control over the industry in recent years.

10. This Scottish economist, writing in 1776, argued that the wealth of nations came not from stockpiling gold but from productive labour and free exchange — a radical idea at the time. Who was he?

b. Adam Smith published 'The Wealth of Nations' in 1776, the same year as American independence, and it was equally revolutionary. His concept of the 'invisible hand' — that individuals pursuing self-interest can unintentionally benefit society — became the intellectual foundation of market economics. Smith also invented the pin-factory example of specialisation that still appears in economics textbooks 250 years later.